

■ By Farzand Ahmed in Phulbani

Every evening Abhimanyu Diggel, 45, leaves the Tikabali relief camp, walks into a church, looks at the destruction, bows before the Cross engraved on the broken walls, and prays: "O Lord, restore sanity and forgive those who destroyed your house, our dwellings and killed my relatives." He is among the 1,300 people, mostly from nearby Breka village, who are living in a relief camp set up at the Tikabali Government High School. Nearly 120 km away from the vandalised church is the Kanya Sanskrit ashram where Kavi Chandranath, in charge of the ashram, along with Hari Chandra Pradhan, vip leader, leads visitors to the spot where Swami Lakshmanananda Saraswati was gunned down on August 23. The duo claim that masked "Christian" youth armed with AK-47s raided the ashram on Janmasthami night and killed four of his disciples and then fired at swamiji who was hiding in an attached bathroom. To ensure he was dead, they slit the veins of his ankles and then disappeared.

The swami's death was the trigger for a wave of anti-Christian violence that has

engulfed the district for the last two weeks targeting Scheduled Caste (SC)-Dalit converts. Within the first four days, at least 18 people were killed and, according to figures released by the Catholic Bishops' Conference of India (CBCI), as many as 42 churches, besides 250 Christian houses and four convents, were torched or razed to the ground, merely on the basis of rumours that after the swami's killing, sweets were distributed in the churches.

But what followed this time has shaken even those who have been witnessing wanton religious or communal violence in Kandhamal since 1994. "I could not believe that human beings would be so cruel against fellow human beings," says 80-year-old Turi Mallick from Sasalanda village, sitting in the relief camp in Phulbani. She describes how she dragged herself to the nearby jungles along with others, starved for two days and then was brought to the camp. Adds Maria Mallick, 45, "The attackers forced us to chant Vande Mataram and Bajrang Bali Ki Jai. Then they poured kerosene on our houses and burnt them." Many of the victims had not even heard about the killing of Saraswati. In the relief camp at Tikabali, Sarojni Nayak, 30, from Barapatti, says she could never forget the hor-

The violence in Orissa reaches unprecedented levels while the political leadership's failure only widens the chasm of hatred

FOR GOD'S SAKE

